during this period. Those with planes, including Massoud's forces and Junbish, bombarded particularly the south and west of Kabul during different periods of the war. Hizb-e-Wahdat also used heavy artillery in its battles with Ittihad and Massoud. All of these attacks, the vast majority of which were indiscriminate and resulted in tens of thousands of civilian casualties, represented grave breaches of the laws of war.'

Ashfaq said that since late 1993, the R&AW had been warning Massoud that the fundamentalist Taliban was being propped up by Pakistan and it was just a matter time before they would arrive in Kabul. In 1995, the Tai-iban, powered by the ISI, took control of Kandahar and subsequently Helmand and Wardak provinces and sharia (Islamic rule) was imposed. Taliban leader Mullah Omar, who headed a twenty-two member council (shura) now decided to capture Kabul and the first attempt was made in late 1995. In early 1996, the Taliban also targeted Jalalabad and gained control of the city on 11 September 1996. On 26 September, Taliban forces entered Kabul.

Ashfaq said, 'The Taliban takeover of Kabul forced all our three assets—Ahmad Shah Mas-soud, Abdul Jaleel and Mirza Murad Rustam— to join hands. They formed a new alliance and we provided whatever we could to help them fight against Taliban expansion. Abdul Jaleel once told me that Pakistan is openly supporting the Taliban with money and weapons. Can you do the same for our forces? If you can do that we will wipe Pakistan off the map."'

Ashfaq was shocked by Jaleel's words, but he understood the deep anguish the Afghan had about the USA-Pakistan nexus that was tearing down their country. 'I told him we cannot do